Soon the Colombo newspapers too were reporting on the fledgling indigenous shipping venture. The *Ceylon Observer*, a Colombo-based newspaper, noted that 'The Swadeshi movement of India has penetrated into Ceylon' and that its representative, V.O. Chidambaram Pillai, was in Colombo to make arrangements for running a steamer service between Tuticorin and Colombo to rival the British India Steam Navigation Company. From its very inception, there was no doubt that the Swadeshi company was pitted against BI. The reports from Colombo were tainted by a negative undertone, which is not surprising given that the papers were all British-owned. 'There is nothing to distinguish [V.O. Chidambaram Pillai] from the ordinary money-lending Chetty, except his knowledge of English', wrote the *Ceylon Observer* patronizingly. Its correspondent, after a brief interview with VOC at Pettah, further reported that the Swadeshi movement was opposed to 'foreign trade', a term he qualified by saying that it included 'British trade'. Having made inroads into the handloom industry, the idea was now to tap into the seafaring trade by starting a new steamer line between Colombo and Tuticorin. When questioned by the reporter about his methods, VOC said he would lecture on the objectives of the movement and canvass support for attaining them. The idea, he said, was to provide the same services as BI. Given that the Tuticorin traders had promised the Swadeshi concern their custom, he was now reaching out to the traders in Colombo. After interviewing VOC, the correspondent sought the views of Bois Bros, the Colombo Agents of BI. Despite the formidable position of BI, Stanley Bois responded cautiously: he would have to wait and watch before commenting. While Sir Stanley was certain that European patronage was in his pocket, he desisted from commenting on the possible loss of 'native custom'. The tact of Sir Stanley notwithstanding, Bois Bros were ruthless businessmen; earlier they had tried to retain 'coolie' custom by shipping them gratis apart from gifting them a piece of cloth.[5]

A less hostile *Times of Ceylon* described VOC as 'a Swadeshi representative'. What was the rationale for starting a Swadeshi venture? Firstly, it was believed that BI was earning between Rs 30,000 and Rs 50,000 per month at the Tuticorin port, and the native merchants wanted a